



NEPAL

Capital city: Kathmandu
Area: 54,363 sq miles (140,800 sq km)
Population: 25,200,000
Official language: Nepali
Major religions: Hindu 90%, Buddhist 5%, Muslim 3%, other 2%
Government: Democratic republic
Currency: Nepalese rupee
Adult literacy rate: 46%
Life expectancy: 60 years
People per doctor: 12,500
Televisions: 6 per 1,000 people

BHUTAN

Capital city: Thimpu
Area: 47,147 sq miles (47,000 sq km)
Population: 2,300,000
Official language: Dzongkha
Major religions: Buddhist 70%, Hindu 24%, other 6%
Government: Absolute monarchy
Currency: Ngultrum
Adult literacy rate: 47%
Life expectancy: 63 years
People per doctor: 6,384
Televisions: 6 per 1,000 people

NEPAL

THE SMALL, ISOLATED country of Nepal lies in the Himalayan mountains and is landlocked (cut off from the sea). Although it is a Hindu state, many people practice both Hinduism and Buddhism. Democratic elections were held for the first time in 1991, but in 1996 revolutionary communists launched a military campaign to overthrow the government. The king suspended constitutional government and introduced monarchical rule once again, but was finally overthrown by parliament in 2008.

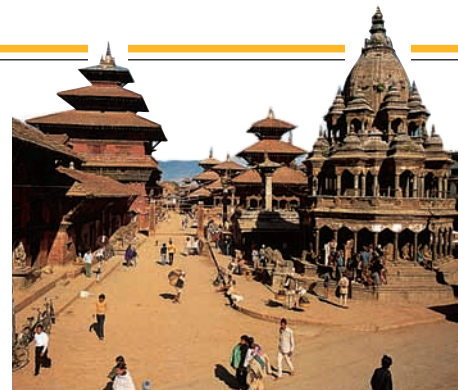


MOUNTAIN TERRACES

About 90 percent of Nepalese people work on the land. Crops such as rice are grown on immaculately kept terraces cut into the mountainsides. This allows farmers to grow crops on land that would otherwise be inaccessible. Farmers depend on the monsoon rains for a good harvest.



These Sherpa women are carrying heavy loads as they trek through the mountains.



KATHMANDU

Kathmandu is the capital and largest city in Nepal. In the old part of the city there are many narrow streets and squares lined with ancient temples and monuments. In one temple lives the Kumari Devi, or living goddess. She is a young girl chosen to represent the Hindu goddess Parvati until she reaches puberty.

NEPALESE PEOPLES

There are many different groups of people living in Nepal. The Sherpas of the eastern mountains are known for their climbing skills. The Gurkha people are famous for their courage and military skills. Their reputation has spread all over the world. The Newars of Kathmandu Valley are known for their magnificent wood carvings, which decorate many Nepali temples and houses. More than half of the people are Nepalese, of Indian descent.

BHUTAN

THE HIMALAYAN KINGDOM of Bhutan is a mysterious, isolated place because of its location in the mountains and its restrictions on tourism. With limited natural resources, Bhutan has been trying to exploit the fast-flowing mountain rivers to produce hydroelectricity. Bhutan is a Buddhist country, ruled by a monarch, a government, and an assembly.

DRUKPAS

About 70 percent of the Bhutanese are Drukpas of Tibetan origin. Clashes between the Drukpas and the Nepali-speaking Lhotsampa people of the south led to violent demonstrations against the government in 1990. Further immigration into Bhutan is banned.

Drukpas speak Dzongkha, the national language of Bhutan, which is closely related to Tibetan.



Bhutanese people eat yak meat, use yak milk to make butter and cheese, and use yak dung as fuel.

Yak hair is used for tents and clothes, and yak tails are used as fans or dusters.

USEFUL YAKS

For many people living in the mountains of Bhutan, life revolves around their herds of yaks. These tough, hardy animals can carry heavy loads and survive freezing temperatures.

Find out more

HIMALAYAS: 132, 166
 HINDUISM & BUDDHISM: 275
 POLITICAL SYSTEMS: 270–271
 TERRACE FARMING: 159, 201